AWAKENINGS: A Preliminary Poll of Circumcised Men

Revealing the Long-Term Harm and Healing the Wounds of Infant Circumcision

Spring 1994 Full report available from NOHARMM • P.O. Box 460795 • San Francisco, CA • 94146

SYNOPSIS

(Sample comments from respondents appear on the reverse of this sheet)

A grassroots ongoing national survey was undertaken of circumcised men who are aware of being harmed to some degree by infant circumcision. This was done in view of the fact that there have been no previous formal scientific studies of the adverse long-term consequences to men of this surgery. Questionnaires were formulated based on the types of harm described by men who had corresponded with circumcision information organizations during a ten year period. The questionnaires were mailed upon request and to men who had contacted foreskin restoration groups. Others were requested by men as a result of learning about the survey through the media.

The physical, sexual and psychological effects were compiled in 1993 from 313 men who responded to the survey. Demographic data was collected only on birth year, birth state, state of residence, race, religion and age at circumcision. Following is a partial demographic overview and a statistical review.

Race:

White: 96.8% African-American: 0.3% Hispanic: 1.3% Asian:0.3% American Indian: 0.3% Other:1%

Religion:

Christian: 77.3% Jewish: 4.2% Moslem: 0% Other (Atheist, Buddhist, etc.): 18.5%

Age: (Average Age: 42)

Under 19: 1% 20-29: 13.1% 30-39: 26.8% 40-49: 33.9% 50-59: 16% Over 60: 9.3%

Age at Circumcision:

Infancy: 89.1% 1-12: 6.1% 13-17: 1% Over 18: 3.8%

Some of the adverse effects reported by survey respondents included:

prominent scarring (29%)
meatal stenosis (constricted urinary opening)
progressive glans insensitivity (55.3%)
excess stimulation needed to orgasm* (38%)
painful erections (11%) from excessive skin loss
low-self esteem or inferiority to intact men (47.3%)
anger over being circumcised ((54.3%)
skin tags (11.8%) and skin bridges (9.9%)
recurrent non-specific urethritis
circumcised too tightly (26.8%)
impedence to sexual relations (42.5%)
dissatisfaction with circumcision (69%)
lack of natural wholeness (60%)
resentment over the surgery (60.4%)
feelings of parental violation (49.5%), mutilation (62%), or betrayal (33.9%)

(* often to the point of discomfort or pain to themselves or their partner)

The survey found that over 60% of respondents had not sought professional help for their harm, mostly because they felt no recourse was available (39.3%), were embarrassed (19.8%) or feared ridicule (15.7%). Half the respondents (50.2%) are involved in uncircumcision (foreskin restoration) methods. Almost 98% of the respondents felt there should be some form of penalty for surgeons who amputate the healthy foreskin from an infant unable to consent to the elective surgery.

The report does not claim to be a random sampling. Hammond states it would be difficult under current conditions to get such a sampling in a culture where many men are led to believe infant circumcision may be beneficial, do not yet know how to identify such harm, believe such adverse effects may be "normal," or otherwise deny that harm exists. Using birth and circumcision data, the group conservatively estimates that between 1940 and 1990, well over 66 million male infants were circumcised in the U.S. It also notes that while the American Academy of Pediatrics has stated that the circumcision complication rate is 0.06%, the AAP acknowledges that "the exact incidence of postoperative complications is unknown." An October 1993 British Journal of Surgery article however, noted that a realistic figure is 2%-10%. According to Hammond, "This means between 1.3 and 6.6 million American males born in that period carry some form of circumcision complication, with an as yet unstudied incidence of related sexual or psychological harm."

It is hoped the NOHARMM survey will provide a foundation for further research. An independent body image survey conducted in 1992 by the men's quarterly *Journeymen*, found 20% of its circumcised male respondents expressed dissatisfaction with their circumcision, versus only 3% of intact men registering dissatisfaction. The survey also found that 78% of intact male respondents were happy with their intact status against only 38% of satisfied circumcised males, leaving a sizable 41% of circumcised men indecisive about how they view the procedure. The *Journeymen* findings lend credibility to the NOHARMM survey and the need to study adverse consequences to men of infant circumcision.

Sample comments from respondents to the Awakenings Survey

[comments followed by state of residence and birth year]

I've been mutilated and denied full functioning of my penis due to an unnecessary and ignorant procedure. CA/1951

My penis is unnatural this way! OH/1956 *Constant, continual chafing and desensitization of glans.* OR/1953

I enjoy no sensations on shaft or glans; orgasm requires painful thrusting. My sexual life is indeed ruined! OH/1966

*Painful erections, scar tissue, insecure (don't feel complete).*NY/1966

My penis has two skin shades, scar much lighter than the shaft. MA/1956

Taking away a part of my body without my permission is a violation of my body and rights. OH/1954

The physical scar is hideous but the emotional scar equates to rape. CA/1947

Have to be at point of abuse and pain to my penis to reach orgasm, it is so desensitized from circumcision. WA/1954

I am angry and bitter and depressed by being circumcised and I resent that it was done to me. MA/1950

The mutilation happened when I was developing a close bond with my mother. I feared closeness because I believed pain would follow. MN/1958

Left with a sense of impotence and powerlessness and a fear about the power of others to hurt me grievously. NY/1930

***I experienced continuous decline in sensitivity and sexual pleasure to the point of not being able to orgasm within a period of time comfortable to my wife. Fortunately, all this has been reversed by my foreskin recovery and I once again have the sexual performance of a teenager.* CA/1945**

Scars still bleed to this day. Takes too long to orgasm due to desensitizing of head. MI/1958

I have always suffered great irritation, redness to the meatus of my penis due to lack of foreskin protection. NJ/1962

My penis curves left from uneven circumcision. MA/1953 *Glans is calloused and numb to subtle sensations.* UT/1950

It hurts too much and sometimes bleeds from being cut so tight. NE/1943

Missing needlessly a vital part of my sexual anatomy, the only moving part. OK/1923
[This gentlemen adds: *Any physician using cosmetic surgery for health purposes should be exposed as a fraud!*]

Skin bridge, large, around 25% of glans-shaft. NJ/1930 *A deep longing to be complete and intact.* GA/1953

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